signed between the British government and the unruly Zakka Khel Afridis in 1857 (Spain, 1962). In light of these traditions and practices, the government of Pakistan had negotiated and concluded at least 13 prominent peace deals, some tacit and unwritten (from 2004 to 2009), all of which had been breached very quickly as both the parties blamed each other for the violations (Terrorism Monitor, 2006).

What is the track record of talks and truces? From 2004 to 2014, eight main agreements took place between the government of Pakistan and the militants, but all ended in fiasco. (The details of the agreements are given below.) These repeated failures of talks and agreements show the importance of following a formula (STOP formula) to initiate and pursue talks or enter into a truce.

STRENGTH, TENACITY, OBJECTIVES AND PREVIOUS PACTS (STOP)

Initiating negotiations from a position of weakness can be counter-productive. Pre-mature approach could give the terrorists and insurgents a feeling of legitimacy and supremacy. Consequently, they talked with confidence and authority and the government ended up giving concessions to them. Decisions on whether to initiate peace negotiations or not should be made on the basis of STOP formula (strength, tenacity, objective and previous pacts). It is imperative to look into detail at the four aspects to have a fair estimate of the chances of success or failure of talks.[1]

– Strength: Are the terrorists operating from a position of weakness or of strength? This is one of the fundamental questions to be addressed to make a decision whether to initiate the talks with the militants or not. As far as TTP was concerned, until 2012, all indications were that TTP and allied groups had not succumbed to pressure created by the army operations and counter-terrorism operations in cities. On 23 February 2012, when the terrorists carried out VBIED attack at Kohat Bus Stand killing 12 persons and injuring 35 others, the Awami National Party (ANP) leaders Haji Adeel and Zahid Khan lambasted the terrorists and said that it was an eye-opener for those who were talking about initiating talks with the terrorists. They said that these terrorists were a plague who wanted to negotiate on their